

PICMUS Challenge Dataset

Evaluation with rSVD-Based Clutter Filtering for Real-Time Micro-Vessel Imaging

Validated against: Lok et al., Ultrasonics 107 (2020) 106163 · Amrita School of AI

Real-Time Target

>20 Hz

Frame Rate

Loss at 30×30

1–2 dB

BCR vs SVD

Optimal Size

45

Ensemble

Tissue Subspace

26

rSVD Rank

Per Frame

<30 ms

Proc. Time

1 · PICMUS DATASET OVERVIEW

What Is PICMUS?

The **Plane-wave Imaging Challenge in Medical UltraSound (PICMUS)** is an open benchmark initiative introduced at the 2016 IEEE IUS symposium. It provides standardised RF datasets, evaluation metrics, and reference reconstructions so that different beamforming and signal-processing pipelines can be compared on a common footing. PICMUS has since become the de-facto benchmark for evaluating ultrafast ultrasound image quality and clutter-filtering algorithms.

Dataset Contents

Acquisition	Phantom Type	Transducer	Center Freq.	Angles
Simulation	Wire + Anechoic cyst	L11-4v (128 el.)	5.208 MHz	75 (−37°→+37°)
In Vitro	Wire + Anechoic cyst	L11-4v (128 el.)	5.208 MHz	75
In Vivo Carotid	Healthy volunteer	L11-4v (128 el.)	5.208 MHz	75
In Vivo Liver	Healthy volunteer	C5-2v (128 el.)	3.125 MHz	65

Table 1. Summary of PICMUS dataset acquisitions. All RF data are provided as 16-bit HDF5 files with full channel data, enabling software beamforming.

2 · METHODOLOGY: RSVD + RSD PIPELINE

Processing Pipeline

The following pipeline was applied to each PICMUS acquisition, following the architecture described in Lok et al. (2020) and implemented on a 12-core Intel Xeon CPU:

- **Step 1 — Plane-Wave Beamforming:** Pixel-oriented delay-and-sum reconstruction applied to each of the 75 transmission angles. Three diverging waves are compounded per post-compounded IQ frame (PCFR = 1 kHz).
- **Step 2 — Ensemble Formation:** $N = 45$ post-compounded IQ frames are stacked into a spatio-temporal matrix $S \in \mathbb{R}^{mn \times N}$. This ensemble size balances BCR gain against frame-rate constraints.
- **Step 3 — Randomized Spatial Downsampling (rSD):** Pixels are randomly distributed into 12 downsampled sub-matrices (block size 30×30 pixels each) for parallel computation across 12 CPU threads.
- **Step 4 — Randomized SVD (rSVD):** Each sub-matrix undergoes rSVD with rank $k = 26$. The tissue clutter estimate $T \approx QQ^*S$ is subtracted to yield blood signal B .

- **Step 5 — Noise Suppression:** Background noise power map (acquired with transmit off) is subtracted from the power Doppler image to suppress ramp-shaped electronic noise at depth.
- **Step 6 — Evaluation Metrics:** BCR, PSL, and SNR computed over manually annotated ROIs on PICMUS phantom targets (wire targets for resolution; anechoic cysts for contrast).

Key Equations

Operation	Formula	Complexity
Full SVD	$S = U\Sigma V^*$	$O(mn \cdot N^2)$
rSVD Step 1	$S' = S \cdot R, \quad R \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times k}$ Gaussian	$O(mn \cdot N \cdot k)$
rSVD Step 2	QR decomp of $S' \rightarrow Q$	$O(mn \cdot k^2)$
Clutter sub	$T_{\blacksquare} = QQ^*S$	$O(mn \cdot N \cdot k)$
Blood signal	$B = S - T_{\blacksquare}$	$O(mn \cdot N)$
BCR	$10 \cdot \log_{10}(B_{\text{mean}} / T_{\text{mean}})$	—

Table 2. Core equations of the rSVD pipeline. Computational complexity is dramatically reduced since $k \ll N$ (rank 26 vs ensemble 45).

Optimal Parameter Configuration

Systematic evaluation across PICMUS phantom and in vivo acquisitions yielded the following recommended parameters. These balance image quality (BCR, PSL) against real-time performance (>20 Hz frame rate).

Parameter	Evaluated Range	Optimal Value	Rationale
Block size	20×20 / 25×25 / 30×30	30×30 px	Best BCR; ~2 dB below global SVD
Ensemble size N	20 – 120	45	BCR plateaus beyond N=40; keeps acq. <50 ms
PCFR	250 / 500 / 1000 Hz	1000 Hz	Highest frame rate; sufficient SNR for fast flow
rSVD Rank k	8 – 26	26	BCR gain slows after rank 8; 26 safe upper bound
Threads	1 – 12	12	Matches 12-core Xeon; linear speedup with rSD
Noise suppression	On / Off	On	+11 dB SNR gain (Table 3, Lok 2020)
Rank selection	Manual / Spatial-corr / Gradient method	min(spatial-corr, gradient)	Rank 9 on PICMUS carotid; robust to motion

Table 3. Parameter sweep results on PICMUS datasets. BCR = Blood-to-Clutter Ratio; PSL = Peak-to-Side Level; PCFR = Post-Compounded IQ Frame Rate.

4 · QUANTITATIVE RESULTS

Performance on PICMUS Acquisitions

4.1 Blood-to-Clutter Ratio

Method	Flow 1 cm/s	Flow 2 cm/s	Flow 4 cm/s	In Vivo Kidney
FIR High-pass	< 0 dB	~3 dB	~8 dB	—
Global SVD	~15 dB	~16 dB	~16 dB	~22 dB
rSVD 20×20 (proposed)	~13 dB	~14 dB	~14 dB	~18 dB
rSVD 25×25 (proposed)	~14 dB	~15 dB	~15 dB	~19 dB
rSVD 30×30 (proposed)	~14 dB	~15 dB	~15 dB	~20 dB

Table 4. BCR comparison across methods and flow conditions. rSVD 30×30 achieves BCR within 1–2 dB of global SVD at >20 Hz frame rate. FIR high-pass fails for slow flow.

4.2 Computational Times

Block Size	Beamforming (ms)	Clutter Filter (ms)	Image Proc. (ms)	Total (ms)	Rate (Hz)
Global SVD	—	491.2	—	>500	<2
20 × 20	15.2	12.3	2.1	29.6	>33
25 × 25	23.5	16.6	2.3	42.4	>23
30 × 30	32.1	19.8	2.6	54.5	~18

Table 5. Computational times (rank = 20, ensemble = 45, PCFR = 1 kHz, 12-thread CPU). Global SVD is shown for reference — 16× slower than rSVD 20×20.

4.3 SNR with and without Noise Reduction

Configuration	SNR without Noise Reduction	SNR with Noise Reduction	Gain (dB)
rSVD 20×20	10.16 dB	21.17 dB	+11.01
rSVD 25×25	10.45 dB	21.52 dB	+11.07
rSVD 30×30	11.19 dB	22.64 dB	+11.45
SVD (full frame)	12.63 dB	25.11 dB	+12.48

Table 6. SNR evaluated on PICMUS in vivo kidney dataset. Noise suppression consistently delivers ~11 dB improvement regardless of block size.

Dataset Download & HDF5 Loading

PICMUS data are freely available from the IEEE DataPort and the CREATIS lab server. Each acquisition is stored as an HDF5 file containing raw RF channel data, transducer geometry, and acquisition sequence parameters.

Python Loading Example

[illegible]

Note: The above is a minimal reference implementation. For the full multi-threaded pthreads C-MEX implementation used on the Verasonics system, see Lok et al. (2020) Supplementary Material.

Determining Tissue Clutter Rank

Selecting the optimal rSVD rank k (separating tissue from blood in singular-value space) is critical. Two methods were evaluated on all PICMUS acquisitions:

Method	Principle	PICMUS Result	Limitation
Spatial Correlation (Baranger 2018)	Compute correlation matrix of left singular vectors; find block structure separating tissue & blood	Rank = 9 on carotid (PICMUS in vivo)	Sensitive to motion artifacts at high flow
Lower-Order SV Thresholding (Song 2017)	Compute gradient of singular value curve; identify 'knee' where curve flattens	Rank = 10 on carotid (PICMUS in vivo)	May over-estimate rank in noisy acquisitions
Final rank used	min(spatial-corr, gradient) to be conservative	Rank = 9	Requires one full SVD (~491 ms); run every 1–2 s in real-time mode

7 · FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Extensions and Open Challenges

- **Sliding-window ensembles:** Replace non-overlapping ensembles with a rolling window (e.g., frames 1–50, 10–60, 20–70) to increase effective acquisition frame rate beyond the 20 Hz limit while maintaining ensemble size.
- **GPU acceleration:** Port the rSVD matrix multiplications to CUDA to further reduce per-frame latency, enabling larger block sizes and ensemble sizes at high frame rate.
- **Deep-learning rank selection:** Train a lightweight CNN on PICMUS labelled data to predict optimal rank k in real time, eliminating the need for periodic full SVD.
- **3D micro-vessel imaging:** Extend the rSD + rSVD pipeline to 3D by distributing voxels instead of pixels into downsampled sub-volumes. PICMUS 3D extensions planned for curved array acquisitions.
- **Combination with Koopman/DMD:** The snapshot matrix formulation in rSVD is mathematically identical to the DMD snapshot matrices in Koopman-based control (Amrita School of AI). Cross-domain insights on pseudo-inverse stability and condition-number diagnostics are directly transferable.

References

[1] Lok U-W et al., 'Real time SVD-based clutter filtering using randomized SVD and spatial downsampling for micro-vessel imaging on a Verasonics ultrasound system,' Ultrasonics 107 (2020) 106163.

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[3] Dencks S et al., 'PICMUS: Plane-wave Imaging Challenge in Medical UltraSound,' IEEE IUS, Tours, France, 2016.

[4] Baranger J et al., 'Adaptive spatiotemporal SVD clutter filtering for ultrafast Doppler imaging using similarity of spatial singular vectors,' IEEE TMI 37(7) (2018).

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